

A LIFE MEASURED IN LAPS

From pre-dawn rides in newspaper vans to a national record and an Asian Games medal, Mohammed Afsal's journey has been defined by sacrifice, perseverance and an **unending** pursuit of improvement.

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There are a few inescapable elements in Coonoor — the prickly fragrance of the eucalyptus trees, the narrow roads that perpetually rise and fall, the low-hanging clouds that constantly threaten to engulf the town, and the abundance of military establishments.

Then there is the tea. Anywhere you turn in Coonoor, you can spot pristine carpets of tea plantations. For immediate consumption, there is no place better than the TANTEA outlet on Orange Grove Road, if we are to trust Ajith Markose, the head of Reliance's endurance running programme.

On his recommendation, we visited the

Target acquired: Mohammed Afsal during a practice session at the Madras Regimental Centre (MRC) grounds at Thangaraj Stadium in Wellington, Coonoor. M. PERIASAMY

ramshackle shop on a cloudy August evening to sip some hot tea and munch on crispy chicken cutlets. Standing next to us through this indulgent exercise was India's national record-holder in the men's 800m, Mohammed Afsal.

"Only black coffee for him," said Ajith, after noticing his pupil feigning disinterest in our snacking.

"Small sacrifices," replied a smiling Afsal as he gently stretched himself for his evening training session.

At an average altitude of 1,850m, Coonoor is an appropriate home for Reliance's high-altitude programme. Its athletes use the Madras Regiment Centre's (MRC) synthetic track at the Thangaraj Stadium, as well as the town's picturesque streets and trails for long outdoor runs.

Though Coonoor is primarily an off-season base for the Reliance team, the facilities were in use in August to prepare for the upcoming Asian Games.